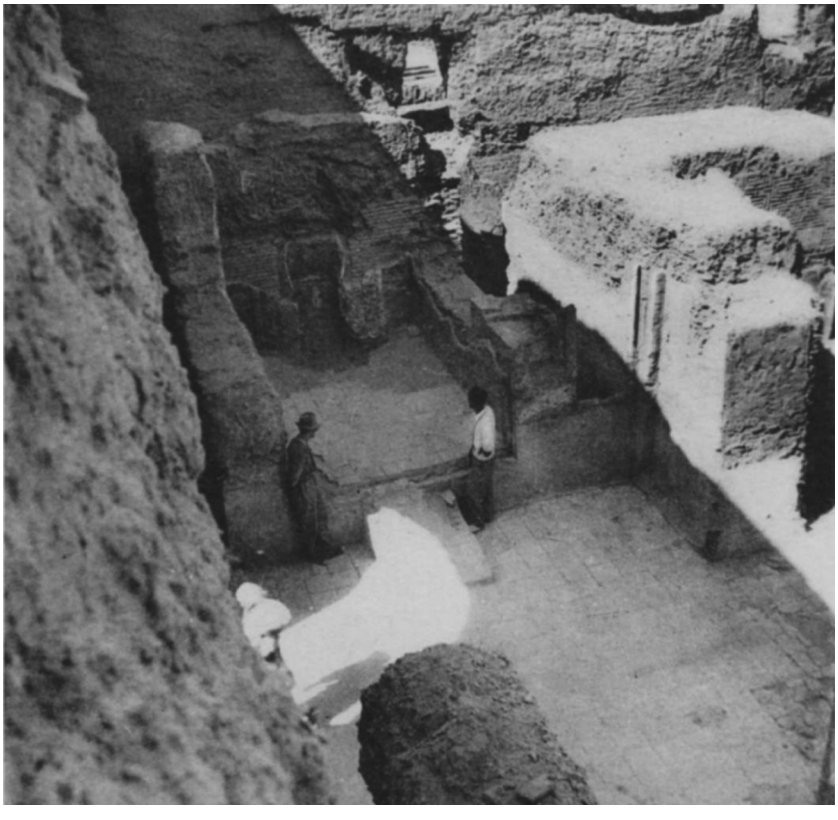


Figure 5.20 *Laskhari Bazar, South Palace, Oratory F, north of central courtyard. From Schlumberger 1952: pl. XXXII, 3.*

in keeping with the later renovations of the same Ghazna palace (Figures 5.6 and 5.7), credited to Mu'izz al-Din (see above).[44] It would not be unreasonable to suggest, then, that the addition of these new decorative programs on the various surfaces of the palace were undertaken within the last quarter of the twelfth century (*c.* AH 570/1175 CE), after the definitive Shansabani conquest of the region, while Mu'izz al-Din was casting himself as successor to the Ghaznavids.

A half-century of new studies has added further nuance to Sourdel-Thomine's conclusions. Specifically, a distinctive South Palace renovation can now be more definitively pinpointed to the last quarter of the twelfth century. The *ivan*-like yet quite intimate prayer space directly abutting the magnificent Audience Hall I to its southwest (Figures 5.14, 5.20), known as Oratory F, surely boasted an exquisite decorative program in its day.[45] On its north and south walls were stucco dadoes with intertwining geometric lozenges framing arabesque-floral motifs, horizontally topped by a running frieze beginning with *Bismillah* on the north wall. The frieze continued with Q. XLVIII:1–6 (al-Fath) extending onto the